

So you're thinking about social work

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-eight careers on how exposed they are to AI.

Statutory child protection: **3.3 out of 10**. Adult safeguarding: **3.8**.

And the thing protecting social work is the strongest protection we found anywhere in the index — stronger than a medical licence.

The reasons to think hard about this one have nothing to do with technology.

The 60-second version

- Statutory social work has the most durable protection in the whole index. And it's not a licence.
 - AI is taking the paperwork — which currently eats 4.3 hours of an 8-hour day.
 - The honest problem is the conditions: turnover runs about six times the average for other jobs.
 - Median tenure in child welfare is 1.8 years. Most people leave before they're fully trained.
 - Which means: the setting you choose matters more here than in almost any career.
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Why it's so protected — and this is genuinely interesting

Most protected careers have a licence. We've argued throughout this index that a licence is only as protective as the act it reserves — pharmacy's covers dispensing, which automates easily; nursing's covers hands-on care, which doesn't.

Statutory social work is a different category entirely.

A normal licence says: *only a qualified person may do this*. It restricts who does the work.

Statutory authority says something else: the state has handed a coercive power to a named individual. A social worker in a statutory role can start the process of removing a child from their parents, or apply for orders restricting an adult's liberty.

Three things follow:

It can't be given to a system, even in principle. A law could be rewritten to let a machine perform a licensed act — that's happened in other fields. But delegated state power over

someone's liberty needs a person who can be held accountable, questioned in court, and struck off. There's no accountable subject for a system to be.

It's written into the deepest kind of law — primary legislation, subject to courts, human rights and public inquiries. The slowest-moving legal architecture there is.

And it's expanding, not shrinking. Safeguarding duties have broadened for two decades.

The transferable idea: when you look at any career's regulation, ask what kind it is. A certificate is weak. A reserved professional act is stronger. Delegated authority over another person's liberty is the strongest thing in this entire index.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Statutory child protection	3.3
Adult safeguarding (statutory)	3.8
Clinical social work (LCSW)	4.3
Medical / hospital social work	4.7
Community / case management	5.4
Policy & programme administration	6.1

Same pattern as everywhere: the further from the family and the statutory decision, the higher the exposure.

What AI is actually doing here

Taking the paperwork — and there's a lot of it.

Federal research found that paperwork and outdated technology consume an average of **4.3 hours of a caseworker's 8-hour day**. More than half the working day on admin.

Case notes, court reports, referral triage, eligibility checks, statutory returns.

And here's why that matters more than it sounds. The profession's own research names administrative burden as one of five documented drivers of burnout — and it's the only one an agency can fix without new laws or new funding.

What it can't touch: sitting in someone's home and judging whether a child is safe. Building trust with a family who don't want you there. Deciding when both acting and not acting carry real risk. And being the named person who has to answer for it.

What we won't soften

The research on working conditions is unambiguous, and you should see it before you choose this.

In child welfare specifically:

- Nearly **80%** of caseworkers report some level of burnout (federal OPRE research)
- **63.7%** report moderate burnout, **49.6%** moderate secondary trauma, and **26.2%** meet diagnostic criteria for PTSD (Child Welfare League of America)
- Turnover runs around **30% a year** — roughly **six times** the average for other occupations
- **Median tenure is about 1.8 years**, and most turnover happens in the first two years

Read that last one carefully. Most child welfare caseworkers leave before they've been fully trained. Which means your colleagues will often be nearly as new as you are.

Caseloads are the other half of it — the recommended standard is around 15, and actual loads frequently run to three times that.

None of this means don't do it. It means the setting you choose is the most important decision in this career.

Because the settings are genuinely different careers

This is the practical takeaway, and it changes the numbers a lot:

SETTING	MEDIAN PAY	GROWTH
Child, family & school	~\$53,940	6%
Mental health & substance abuse	~\$60,060	10%
Healthcare / hospital	~\$68,090	8%
Licensed clinical (private practice)	\$75,000–\$125,000+	—

Overall BLS median is **\$61,330**, with the top 10% above **\$99,500**.

Healthcare social work pays the most and grows second-fastest. Child welfare pays least and has the worst conditions. Same qualification.

And the demand is real: around 40% of the US population lives in a designated mental health professional shortage area — 97% in Texas.

One more thing worth knowing: Public Service Loan Forgiveness applies across most of this sector, which changes the debt maths considerably compared with other helping professions.

Does this actually sound like you?

The trait that predicts who stays: can you sit with distress without absorbing it?

Not "do you care" — everyone entering this cares. Whether you can be close to something awful, be genuinely useful, and then put it down.

It also suits people who:

- Are **comfortable being unwelcome** — statutory work often means being somewhere nobody wants you
- Can **hold uncertainty and still decide** — both acting and not acting carry risk
- Are **organised**, because the recording is real even after automation
- Have genuine support outside work. This matters more here than in almost any career.

Harder if you need to fix things. A lot of situations don't resolve. Some get worse.

And one honest misapprehension worth clearing up: a lot of people come to social work imagining helping. Statutory work is frequently about *authority* rather than assistance — you are there because the state sent you, and the family often knows it.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **Placements — how many, which settings, and can you get a statutory one?** This shapes your career more than the degree does.
 - **How is risk assessment actually taught?** With real practice and feedback, or theoretically?
 - **Does it prepare you for the emotional side** — secondary trauma, reflective supervision — properly rather than as an add-on?
 - **Does it map to LCSW requirements** where you want to practise?
 - **Where do graduates work at one year — by setting?**
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Two things worth doing

Get real exposure to people in difficulty first. Support work, care work, a helpline. It answers the "is this me" question faster than anything else — and it's what the good courses want to see on an application anyway.

Then find a social worker three to five years in — past the median tenure — and ask what kept them. That answer is the most useful thing you'll hear about this career.

And one thing to remember for later

When you're being interviewed for your first job: **ask about caseload numbers and how often you'd get supervision.** Treat an evasive answer as an answer.

With turnover at 30% and median tenure at 1.8 years, **choosing your employer is essentially choosing whether you stay in the profession.** Very few people your age know to ask.

One last thing

Social work is one of a small number of careers where the work is straightforwardly worth doing — and where the thing protecting it is that **society decided only a human being should hold this kind of power over another person's life.**

That's a genuinely good reason to do it.

The conditions above are a genuinely good reason to be deliberate about *where*.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **Social Workers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — government pay and growth data by specialism. The variation between settings is the useful bit.
 - **Child Welfare League of America** — the burnout and turnover research. Hard reading, published by the sector so it can be fixed.
 - **OPRE workforce research** — federal research including the 4.3-hours-of-8 finding.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by setting, how they were worked out, the conditions data in detail, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.